

Designing questionnaires for research

Why use questionnaires?

Limitations of questionnaires?

Planning a questionnaire

What and why - decide on aims and on the information you need before you frame the questions

Who – decide on who you will design the questionnaire for - eg managers, female staff

How - decide on the method and the time frame

Design: need for:

Clear instructions to potential respondents

Clear questions

Helpful sequencing of questions

Clear layout

Clear answer scales

11 steps for questionnaire design

Z O'Leary (2010)

1. Operationalize concepts
2. Explore existing possibilities
3. Draft questions
4. Decide on response categories – eg Yes/No, sliding scale, how many response categories, free text
5. Review – could your questions be considered ambiguous, leading, confronting, offensive, based on unwarranted assumptions, double-barrelled, or pretentious? On occasion you may need to take advice from local experts

6. Rewrite questions and review them
7. Repeat stage 6 as many times as necessary
8. Order questions – use a logical order. Try to use some interesting ones early on in the questionnaire
9. Write clear instructions
10. Lay out – clear and pleasing lay out and design
11. Write a cover letter/introductory statement

How many questions?

How many respondents?

What kind of response categories?

Likert scale

Yes/no to a number of items

Select one response

Select all responses that apply

Rank responses

Forced choice between two alternatives

Distribute points between alternatives

1. How frequently, in your experience, does the following problem occur: employees being afraid to express disagreement with their managers

1
Very
seldom

2

3

4

5
Very
frequently

2. Company rules should not be broken – even when the employee thinks it is in the company's best interest

1	2	3	4	5
Strongly agree	Agree	Neither agree nor disagree	Disagree	Strongly disagree

Helpful activities

Look for published questionnaires in the area of interest – could you use them? Could you adapt them?

Look carefully at any questionnaires that are sent to you – what are their strengths, what are their weaknesses?

Leave time to design, draft, review and re-draft your questionnaire. Review and re-drafting takes time. Get help for this if you can.

Can your target group access electronic questionnaires? If so, explore the software available to distribute them – the software will also help you to analyse the results.

References

Zina O'Leary 2010 *The Essential Guide to Doing Your Research Project*, Sage 'Direct Data Collection: Surveys and Interviews' pp 180-207 – [an updated edition is](#)

Zina O'Leary 2017 *The Essential Guide to doing your research project*, Sage ch 12 'Primary Data: Surveys, Interviews and Observation' pp. 223-262

*G Hofstede, GJ Hofstede and M Minkov 2010 *Cultures and Organizations* McGraw Hill: New York

#A chapter from this book is available as part of the Moodle resources for this module

* This is an e-book in the University library

Further reading

*Martyn Denscombe 2007 *The Good Research Guide*, OU/McGraw Hill

#Pervez Ghauri and Kjell Gronhaug 2010 *Research Methods in Business Studies* FT Prentice Hall: Harlow

#AN Oppenheim 1992 *Questionnaire design, interviewing and attitude measurement* Continuum:London

#Michael Wilson and Roger Sapsford 2006 'Asking Questions' from Roger Sapsford and Victor Jupp (eds) *Data Collection and Analysis* 2nd ed Sage: London

#Gina Wisker 2008 *The Postgraduate Research Handbook* 2nd ed Palgrave Macmillan: Basingstoke

#A chapter from these books is available as part of the Moodle resources for this module

* These are e-books in the University library